

Realme Buds Air 8 Pro

Expressive and easy to recommend

Ever since I reviewed the Realme Buds Air 8, I have been waiting for the Pro model. I was very impressed with the standard model and was curious to see how Realme ups the ante. The newcomer carries a price tag of Rs 6999 in India and brings dual drivers, 55dB active noise cancellation, LHDC 5.0 audio support, long battery life, and a dedicated bone-conduction microphone for calls (I'll tell you all about it in a bit). On paper, it looks like a very interesting TWS earphone for the price, but is it really good in everyday use? Let's find out.

Here's my experience after spending time with the Realme Buds Air 8 Pro for several weeks now in my home, office, metro and rickshaw commutes, watching movies, listening to music and taking calls, and sometimes just wearing them to avoid people and noise. It wasn't perfect, but very close. Let's dive in.

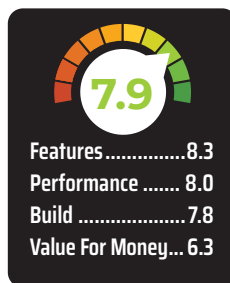
VERDICT

The Realme Buds Air 8 Pro is one of the most complete TWS earphones you can buy under Rs 7,000. It offers expressive sound, effective ANC, reliable call quality, long battery life, and a comfortable fit. Granted, the Realme Link app still needs some refinement, and the glossy design won't be for everyone, but these are minor qualms in an otherwise well-rounded package that is easy to recommend.

DESIGN AND COMFORT

The Realme Buds Air 8 Pro come in Master Black and Master White colour options. Our review unit came in the white finish, which combines a matte body with a glossy metallic top. This is very reflective, and you can even see your face in it. The lustrous surface attracts a lot of smudges, too, especially

₹6,999



on the case. The earbuds also have a glossy, steel-like finish on the stems, which gives them a distinct look. However, if I had to pick this or the more sober and sophisticated finish of the black one, I would go with the latter.

The Realme Buds Air 8 Pro case is compact and pocket-friendly. Both its and the buds' build quality is reassuring. The buds sit securely inside the ears without much pressure. One day, it started drizzling during my commute back home, but I confidently kept wearing them thanks to the IP55 ingress protection rating.

Overall, the design is practical and comfortable. The glossy case element may be slightly divisive, but that hardly comes in the way of your actual wearability and usage.

CONNECTIVITY AND CONTROLS

You get a quick and straightforward pairing experience on Android thanks

to Fast Pair, and I had no issue connecting it with my MacBook. It should work fine with iPhone and Windows, too. Pairing was followed by a no-fuss connectivity experience. It runs on Bluetooth 6.1 and supports simultaneous connection with three devices, and allows seamless taking calls or switching music playback between these devices. The only catch is that if you are listening to Spotify on your phone and trying to watch a YouTube video on your laptop, you'll have to pause one to start listening on the other.

The Realme Link app is one of the better companion apps in this segment. It needs logging in, and once you do that, you can see all your Realme audio, smart home and fitness-oriented products. Tap the Buds Air 8 Pro from the list, and you can see the earbuds' battery percentage and various settings like ANC controls, EQ presets, firmware updates, wear detection settings, Game mode (low latency), and audio personalisation settings.

On one hand, features like tap-based controls are fairly customisable and quite responsive too. The swipe up/down gesture on the buds' stems to control volume is particularly useful. But the app needs some polishing. You see, I used the hearing test feature called Golden Sound to generate a profile. I applied it and was pleased by the result, but later, one day when the app prompted me to re-log in, after logging in, the saved profile was missing.

Other rough edges include the Ask AI feature (which uses Gemini), wasn't working because of a busy server. Similarly, Mindflow mode wasn't working. Face to Face Translate feature also wasn't working as seamlessly as I would have wanted it to, even though I had given it the microphone permissions.

All these things don't necessarily impact the audio experience of the earbuds, so I can give them a pass. It's just that the software experience needs to be more refined.